CAPSTONE, PORTFOLIO & INTERVIEWS · LESSON 7 OF 10

Behavioural Interviews and STAR Answers

Prepare answers to seven common behavioural questions using the STAR method (Situation, Task, Action, Result). Learn to structure a two-minute story, show your own contribution, include a measurable result, and tell an honest story about a failure or a conflict.

Gap-fill lesson | ✦ 2026 | Beginner | ⏱ 90 min

By the end of this lesson you can

- Structure a behavioural answer using STAR
- Describe your own actions clearly, without taking credit for the team's work
- Include a result, with a number where possible
- Talk honestly about a failed project and what changed afterwards

The STAR method

Behavioural questions ask "tell me about a time when..." The interviewer wants evidence of how you actually work. The **STAR** structure gives a clear story in about two minutes:

Part	Length	What to say
Situation	1–2 sentences	Where you were, what the context was
Task	1 sentence	What you were responsible for
Action	60–90 seconds	What you did, step by step, using "I" for your own work
Result	20–30 seconds	What changed, with a measure, and what you learned

Most weak answers spend too long on the situation and not enough on the action and result. Aim for the action to be the longest part.

CASE STUDY **The same project, told two ways**

A weak answer: "We had a messy spreadsheet and the team was struggling, so we worked on it and it got better." A STAR answer: "Our monthly churn report was built by hand and took two days, with errors found by finance each time. My task was to automate it without changing the numbers. I wrote a cleaning script with checks for each source, compared its output with the manual report for three months, and set up a scheduled run. The report now takes ten minutes and the variance to finance is under 0.5%." The second answer names the action and the measure.

Question 1: tell me about yourself

Use a 90-second version: your current role or study, two relevant skills with an example each, and why this role. End with a sentence connecting to the job. Do not recite your CV.

Question 2: explain a difficult project

Choose a project with real obstacles. Describe the constraint (data quality, a deadline, a changing requirement), the step you took to get past it, and what you would do differently. A project that was hard but went well is a good choice.

Question 3: describe a problem you solved

Pick a problem with a clear cause and a verifiable fix. Show how you diagnosed it: what you checked first, what the evidence showed, and why you chose the fix you did. Quantify the result where you can.

Question 4: explain a conflict with a stakeholder

Describe the disagreement fairly, including the other person's valid concern. Show how you found common ground: a shared definition, a small pilot or a data check. Avoid describing the other person as the problem; describe what you changed in how you worked together.

Question 5: describe a failed project

Be honest. Choose a real failure with a lesson. Explain what you expected, what went wrong, what you did when you noticed, and what you do differently now. Interviewers trust candidates who can

name a mistake and show a changed habit.

> **WATCH OUT** **Do not invent results**
>
> Never state a number you cannot support. If the result is qualitative, say so: "the team adopted it, and two colleagues now use the same check." If you do not know the impact, say how you would measure it. Interviewers often ask a follow-up about the number, and an invented figure falls apart.

Question 6: how do you prioritise work?

Describe a method you actually use: for example, ranking by business impact and effort, asking the requester what decision the work supports, and reviewing the list weekly. Give one example where you said no or postponed a request, and why.

Question 7: how do you explain technical concepts to non-technical stakeholders?

Show a technique: start with the decision, use one concrete example, avoid jargon or define it once, and check understanding by asking the person to restate the implication. Give an example where a chart or a single number replaced a long explanation.

Preparing your stories

Prepare five stories that each cover different themes (a success, a failure, a conflict, a difficult deadline, a learning moment). Each story can answer several questions. Write each in STAR form, time it, and practise until it fits in about two minutes without notes.

Story	Useful for questions
Automated the monthly report	2, 3, 6
Disagreement over a metric definition	4, 7
A pipeline failure that taught a lesson	2, 5
A dashboard that went unused	5, 6, 7
A course or project you completed on your own	1, 3

::::tip Practise with a recording Record your answers on a phone. Check whether the action is the longest part, whether you say "I" for your own work, and whether the result has a number or a clear

change. Re-record until each answer lands in two minutes. ::::

::::key What to remember - Use STAR: short situation and task, a detailed action, and a result with a measure. - Say "I" for what you did; say "we" for the team's work, and be clear about your share. - Never invent numbers; say how you would measure an unknown impact. - Prepare five stories that cover several questions each. ::::

Quick quiz

5 questions · tap an answer to check it

1. Which part of STAR should be the longest?

- **A** Situation
- **B** Task
- **C** Action
- **D** Result

Answer: C. The action is where the interviewer learns how you work.

2. What makes a result strong in a STAR answer?

- **A** It is vague and modest
- **B** It names a change, ideally with a measure
- **C** It describes the team's pride
- **D** It is left out

Answer: B. A measure or clear change shows the impact of your work.

3. In a question about a failed project, what do interviewers value most?

A A story with no failure

B A real failure, what you did about it, and a changed habit

C Blaming others

D A list of tools

Answer: B. Honesty and learning are what they listen for.

4. Why prepare five stories rather than many?

A Interviews allow only five

B Each story can answer several questions, and five are easier to practise well

C Five is the legal minimum

D Stories should never be reused

Answer: B. A small set of well-practised stories covers most questions.

5. What should you do if you do not know the impact of a project?

A Estimate a number that sounds plausible

B Say how you would measure it or describe the qualitative change honestly

C Avoid mentioning the project

D Change the subject

Answer: B. Honest answers survive follow-up questions; invented ones do not.

EXERCISE **Write five stories**

Write five STAR stories from your own experience, study or volunteering: a success, a failure, a conflict, a deadline and a learning moment. Time each one out loud, and map each to the seven questions above.

Show solution (worked answer)

Hints: if you lack workplace examples, use a project you did alone, a course assignment, or a volunteer activity; the structure is the same. Mark the action sentences and check that each contains "I" and a concrete verb.

Practise more online

Free, trusted places to test yourself on this topic. Links open the original site in a new tab.